project means less code for you to write and maintain. How to use APIs with Django is covered in chapter 11.

Django has been around for a long time; its first release at the *Lawrence Journal-World* was in 2003. It can no longer be described as "the new kid on the block." The programming world has a tendency toward rejecting the old, but a distinction should be made between dinosaurs and sharks. Dinosaurs are extinct. Sharks were around with the dinosaurs, but they are still mean, eating machines today. Django is actively being developed and still releases major versions annually. Recent releases have focused on redesigning the underlying technology to better support asynchronous coding, making Django competitive with newer web development stacks.

Django isn't just a shark but a shark with accessories; it's modular in design and supports plugins. There are thousands of plugins available—one of which may already do what you were going to code for yourself. The Django Packages site (https://djangopackages.org/) has over 4,000 installable libraries that cover topics such as analytics, data tools, e-commerce, feed aggregation, forums, payment processing, polls, reporting, and social media. Whatever web application you want to build, there is likely a package that can help you.

Django's vast ecosystem is a real advantage, but even outside the Python world, there are things making Django better. HTMX is a JavaScript library that allows you to replace part of an active page with a snippet of HTML. You do this without having to write any JavaScript at all. Suddenly, Django's ability to serve and handle pieces of HTML, when combined with HTMX, means a resurgence of dynamic webpages without resorting to heavier, single-page application frameworks. Making your pages more dynamic using HTMX is covered in chapter 12.

1.2.3 Potential projects

There are many types of websites out there, and depending on what you're building, you may end up using different parts of the Django framework. The following is an incomplete list of the types of projects you might be interested in:

- *Blogs*—These are a natural fit for Django, with the ORM storing article content and views responsible for showing articles and table-of-contents pages. Wiki sites and newspapers are a variation on this, where instead of blog posts, you have encyclopedic information or newspaper articles as content.
- *e-commerce sites*—These sites are all about the catalog. The ORM stores information about your merchandise, while the views present them to the users. In complex sites, you may be interacting with an inventory backend instead or exporting shopping patterns for data analysis. The Django Admin provides an out-of-the-box inventory management system by working in conjunction with the ORM.
- *Content sites*—Many websites are repositories of specialty information. Consider the Internet Movie Database (IMDB); it is really a frontend to a database entry describing information about a movie. Django's ORM and the Django Admin make it a good tool for these kinds of sites.